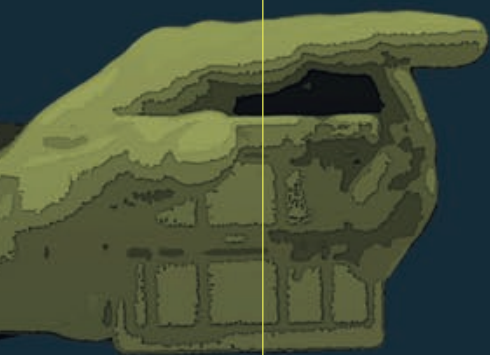


IFAB®

THE INTERNATIONAL FOOTBALL ASSOCIATION BOARD



Laws of the Game 25/26



Download
Laws of the Game App

IFAB[®]

THE INTERNATIONAL FOOTBALL ASSOCIATION BOARD



FIFA[®]



14

10

9

The International Football Association Board
Münstergasse 9, 8001 Zurich, Switzerland
T: +41 (0)44 245 1886, F: +41 (0)44 245 1887
www.theifab.com

This booklet may not be reproduced or translated in whole or in part in any manner without the permission of The International Football Association Board.

Selected images kindly provided by FIFA and the respective confederations, and used with their permission.

Effective from 1st July 2025

Laws of the Game 2025/26

Contents

About the Laws	9
Notes and modifications	16
Notes on the Laws of the Game	17
General modifications	20
'Only the captain' guidelines	24
Guidelines for temporary dismissals (sin bins)	28
Guidelines for return substitutes	32
Additional permanent concussion substitutions protocol	34
Laws of the Game 2025/26	39
1 The Field of Play	41
2 The Ball	51
3 The Players	55
4 The Players' Equipment	63
5 The Referee	69
6 The Other Match Officials	79
7 The Duration of the Match	87
8 The Start and Restart of Play	91
9 The Ball in and out of Play	95
10 Determining the Outcome of a Match	97
11 Offside	103
12 Fouls and Misconduct	109
13 Free Kicks	125
14 The Penalty Kick	129
15 The Throw-in	135
16 The Goal Kick	139
17 The Corner Kick	143

Video assistant referee (VAR) protocol	146
FIFA Quality Programme	156
Law changes 2025/26	160
Outline summary of Law changes	161
Details of all Law changes	164
Glossary	172
Football bodies	173
Football terms	174
Referee terms	184
Practical guidelines for match officials	186
Introduction	187
Positioning, movement and teamwork	188
Body language, communication and whistle	202
Other advice	208

About
the Laws

The philosophy and spirit of the Laws

Football is the greatest sport on earth. It is played on every continent, in every country and at many different levels. The fact that the Laws of the Game are the same for all football throughout the world, from the FIFA World Cup™ through to a game between young children in a remote village, is a considerable strength which must continue to be harnessed for the good of football everywhere.

Football must have Laws which keep the game fair – this is a crucial foundation of the ‘beautiful game’ and a vital feature of the ‘spirit’ of the game. The best matches are those where the referee is rarely needed because the players play with respect for each other, the match officials and the Laws.

Football’s Laws are relatively simple compared to most other team sports, but as many situations are subjective and match officials are human, some decisions will inevitably be wrong or cause debate and discussion. For some people, this discussion is part of the game’s enjoyment and attraction but, whether decisions are right or wrong, the ‘spirit’ of the game requires that referees’ decisions must always be respected. All those in authority, especially coaches and team captains, have a clear responsibility to the game to respect the match officials and their decisions.

The Laws cannot deal with every possible situation, so where there is no direct provision in the Laws, The IFAB expects the referee to make a decision within the ‘spirit’ of the game and the Laws – this often involves asking the question, ‘what would football want/expect?’

Poor participant behaviour is an area of increasingly great concern, and it is essential that everyone involved in the game be treated with respect to keep it enjoyable and fair. Following their successful implementation in several countries, the ‘Only the captain’ guidelines are now included as a

recommendation in the Laws, as there is widespread confidence that having only the captain approach the referee after major incidents/decisions will greatly improve interactions between the players and the referee, as well as the overall atmosphere on the field of play and the image of the game. This is vital for the game's future, including the recruitment and retention of referees.

During 2024/25, trials were conducted to deal more effectively with goalkeepers holding the ball for too long. As a result, Law 12 has been changed so that goalkeepers will now be penalised if they hold the ball for more than eight seconds, with a corner kick being awarded to the opposition in such cases. The trials clearly demonstrated that a corner kick is an effective deterrent that is easier to manage and can be set up much more quickly than an indirect free kick in the penalty area. The eight seconds will be strictly enforced by the referee, who will visually count down the last five seconds with the fingers of a raised hand.

As a result of another successful trial, competitions now have the option of the referee announcing and explaining the final decision after a video assistant referee (VAR) 'review' or lengthy VAR 'check'.

The Laws must also contribute to the safety and welfare of players and it is The IFAB's responsibility to react quickly and appropriately to support the game's participants, through the Laws themselves, when the need arises.

To that end, competitions have the option of allowing the use of 'additional permanent concussion substitutions'. This enables teams to prioritise the welfare of a player who has an actual or suspected concussion without suffering a numerical disadvantage.

Accidents inevitably occur, but the Laws aim to help make the game as safe as possible, balancing player welfare and sporting fairness. This requires referees to use the Laws to deal strongly with those players whose actions are too aggressive or dangerous. The Laws embody the unacceptability of unsafe play in their disciplinary phrases, such as 'reckless challenge' and 'endangering the safety of an opponent' or 'using excessive force'.

To promote a greater understanding of the Laws, The IFAB has published 'Football Rules – simplified Laws of the Game', which have been written to make the Laws easier to understand, especially for young people, potential or newly qualified referees, adults who referee occasionally, players, coaches, spectators and the media.

Visit www.footballrules.com to access or download Football Rules, which can be sorted alphabetically or by category.

An audio version of the Laws of the Game can be accessed at: www.theifab.com.

Managing changes to the Laws

Football must remain attractive and enjoyable for players, match officials and coaches, as well as spectators, fans and administrators, regardless of age, gender, race, religion, culture, ethnicity, sexual orientation or disability.

It is also crucial to uphold the universality of the Laws to allow young players to watch matches on television and then attempt to replicate what they have seen on the field. Therefore, any changes to the Laws must benefit the game as a whole, which often requires testing or trialling the proposed modifications first.

For every proposed change, the focus is on fairness, integrity, respect, safety, the enjoyment of participants and spectators and, where appropriate, using technology to enhance the game.

The IFAB will continue to work with its advisory panels and engage in extensive consultations with stakeholders so that changes to the Laws benefit football at all levels and in every corner of the world. This should help ensure that the integrity of the game, the Laws themselves and the match officials are respected, valued and protected.

The IFAB greatly values its engagement with people worldwide and is always happy to receive suggestions or questions relating to the Laws of the Game. Please continue to send your ideas, suggestions and questions to: **lawenquiries@theifab.com**.

For more information on the history of the Laws of the Game and current developments, including trials, please visit our website: **www.theifab.com**.



Notes on the Laws of the Game

Official languages

The IFAB publishes the Laws of the Game in English, French, German and Spanish. If there is any divergence in the wording, the English text is authoritative.

Other languages

National football associations (FAs) which translate the Laws of the Game can obtain the layout template for the 2025/26 edition of the Laws from The IFAB by contacting: info@theifab.com.

National FAs which produce a translated version of the Laws of the Game using this format are invited to send a copy to The IFAB (stating clearly on the front cover that it is that national FA's official translation) so it can be posted on The IFAB's website for use by others.

Measurements

If there is any divergence between metric and imperial units, the metric units are authoritative.

Applying the Laws

The same Laws apply in every match in every confederation, country, town and village and, apart from the modifications permitted by The IFAB (see 'General modifications'), **the Laws must not be modified or changed, except with the permission of The IFAB.**

Those who are educating match officials and other participants should emphasise that:

- referees should apply the Laws within the 'spirit' of the game to help produce fair and safe matches

Notes and modifications

- everyone must respect the match officials and their decisions, remembering and respecting that referees are human and will make mistakes

Players have a major responsibility for the image of the game and the team captain should play an important role in helping to ensure that the Laws and referees' decisions are respected.

Key

The main Law changes are underlined in yellow and highlighted in the margin. Editorial changes are underlined.

YC = yellow card (caution); RC = red card (sending-off).



General modifications

The universality of the Laws of the Game means that the game is essentially the same in every part of the world and at every level. As well as creating a 'fair' and safe environment in which the game is played, the Laws should also promote participation and enjoyment.

Historically, The IFAB has allowed national football associations (FAs) some flexibility to modify the 'organisational' Laws for specific categories of football. The IFAB strongly believes that national FAs should be able to modify some aspects of the way football is organised if it will benefit football in their own country.

How the game is played and refereed should be the same on every football field in the world, from the FIFA World Cup™ final to the smallest village. However, the needs of a country's domestic football should determine how long the game lasts, how many people can take part and how some unfair behaviour is punished.

All national FAs (and confederations and FIFA) have the option to modify all or some of the following organisational areas of the Laws of the Game for football for which they are responsible:

For all levels of the game:

- the number of substitutions each team is permitted to use up to a maximum of five*, except in youth football, where the maximum will be determined by the national association, confederation or FIFA
- the use of additional permanent concussion substitutions (applying The IFAB's protocol)
- the implementation of the 'Only the captain' guidelines

**See also Law 3 for the conditions that apply to matches that go to extra time and details on the restriction on substitution opportunities.*

For youth, veterans, disability and grassroots football:

- size of the field of play
- size, weight and material of the ball
- width between the goalposts and height of the crossbar from the ground
- duration of the two (equal) halves of the game (and two equal halves of extra time)
- number of players
- use of return substitutes
- use of temporary dismissals (sin bins) for some/all cautions (YCs)
- specific requirements for the captain's compulsory armband

In addition, to allow national FAs further flexibility to benefit and develop their domestic football, the following changes relating to 'categories' of football are permitted:

- national FAs, confederations and FIFA have the flexibility to decide the age restrictions for youth and veterans football
- each national FA will determine which competitions at the lowest levels of football are designated as 'grassroots' football

The IFAB's trials

There are times when a potential Law change needs to be tested or trialed to evaluate both the expected and unexpected impacts that it may have on the game. Confederations, national FAs and competition organisers must have permission from The IFAB to take part in any such trials.

In 2025/26, The IFAB will continue to oversee trials at lower levels of the game involving official cooling-off periods following some confrontation situations.

Further details on, and the protocols for, all trials may be found at www.theifab.com (in the 'Trials' section).

Those wishing to apply to take part in any trial should contact The IFAB using: trials@theifab.com.

Permission for other modifications

National FAs have the option to approve any of the above modifications for different competitions – there is no requirement to apply them universally or to apply them all. **However, no other modifications are allowed without the permission of The IFAB.**

National FAs are asked to inform The IFAB of their use of these modifications, and at which levels, as this information, and especially the reason(s) why the modifications are being used, may identify development ideas or strategies which The IFAB can share to assist the development of football in other national FAs.

The IFAB would also be very interested to hear about other potential modifications to the Laws of the Game which could increase participation, make football more attractive and promote its worldwide development.



'Only the captain' guidelines

Introduction

Respect and fairness are core values of football, but referees and other match officials are regularly subjected to verbal and/or physical dissent when they make decisions. In extreme cases, players sometimes run at referees and surround or mob them, which shows a lack of respect for the referee, harms the image of the game and can be intimidating and upsetting.

Stronger collaboration between the referee and the team captains can help instil fairness and mutual respect. In this regard, so that the referee can explain key decisions, only the captains will be allowed to approach the referee, provided that they do so respectfully and conduct themselves as such. At the same time, it will be the responsibility of each captain to ensure that their team-mates remain a reasonable distance from the referee and do not interfere in the interaction between the referee and the team captain(s).

The following simple guidelines should assist organisers of competitions wishing to apply the 'only the captain' principles.

Guidelines

- Normal interactions between players and the referee are allowed and remain important (to promote transparency and avoid possible frustration and conflict)
- Any player (including the captain) who shows dissent by word or action will be cautioned (yellow card)
- The referee will, where appropriate, explain important decisions to the captain(s) and/or the player(s) involved in an incident

- To prevent players mobbing or surrounding the referee in major situations and following key incidents or decisions:
 - only one player from each team – usually the captain – is allowed to approach the referee and, when doing so, they must always interact in a respectful manner
 - the referee may instruct/encourage players (verbally or with gestures) not to approach them
 - the team captains are responsible for helping to direct their team-mates away from the referee
 - players who approach/surround the referee when they are not permitted to do so may be cautioned (yellow card)
 - if appropriate, the referee may delay the restart of play to allow the captain(s) time to speak with their team-mates to explain a decision, demand proper behaviour, etc.
- Interaction with, or an approach by, any player other than the captain is at the discretion of the referee, e.g. if the player has committed an offence, been fouled and/or is injured

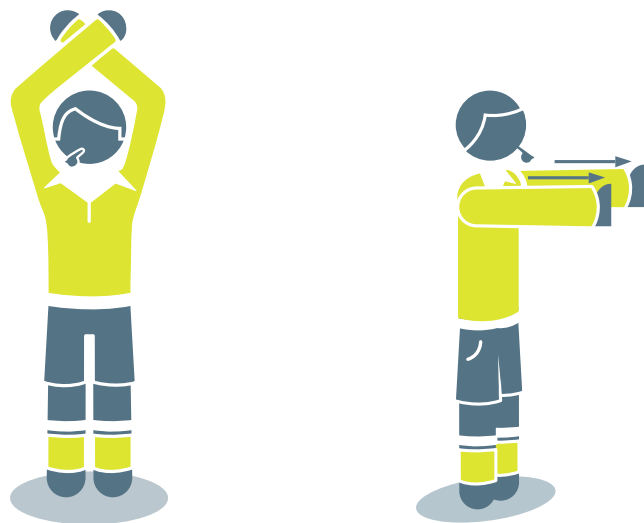
When the captain is the goalkeeper

- Where the goalkeeper is the captain, the referee must be told, no later than at the coin toss before kick-off, which player is nominated to approach the referee instead of the goalkeeper
- Only the goalkeeper or the nominated player, not both, may approach the referee
- If the nominated player is substituted or sent off, another player must be nominated

Option for youth, veterans, disability and grassroots football

The guidelines below apply only to youth, veterans, disability and grassroots football.

- The referee can initiate the 'only the captain' guidelines by blowing the whistle and using the following signal:
 - Raising both arms above their head and crossing them at the wrists
 - Uncrossing their arms and moving them in front of their body with their palms open in a forward pushing motion to indicate that the players must not approach



- A captain-only zone will then extend for 4 m (4.5 yds) around the referee
- Where appropriate, the referee may move away from the players to create the captain-only zone
- No player is permitted to enter the captain-only zone except each team's captain, who should wear an identifying armband
- The captain has a degree of responsibility for encouraging team-mates to respect the captain-only zone and remain at least 4 m (4.5 yds) away from the referee

- If one player other than the captain enters the captain-only zone, the offender should be cautioned (YC) for dissent by action
- If more than one player from a team enters the captain-only zone, at least one player must be cautioned (YC) – this will usually be the first unauthorised player to enter the captain-only zone or the player whose approach is most aggressive
- Any incident in which more than one unauthorised player from a team enters the captain-only zone must be reported to the appropriate authorities after the match*

**It is strongly recommended that competition organisers have sanctions in place to deal with situations where more than one player from a team enters the captain-only zone.*

Guidelines for temporary dismissals (sin bins)

Introduction

Temporary dismissals (sin bins) for all or some cautionable (YC) offences are an option in youth, veterans, disability and grassroots football competitions, subject to the approval of the competition's national FA, confederation or FIFA (whichever is appropriate).

The 138th Annual General Meeting of The IFAB approved a revised version of the 'Guidelines for temporary dismissals (sin bins)'.

Reference to temporary dismissals is found in:

Law 5. The Referee

5.3 Powers and duties – Disciplinary action

The referee has the power to show yellow or red cards and, where competition rules permit, temporarily dismiss a player, from entering the field of play at the start of the match until after the match has ended, including during the half-time interval, extra time and penalties (penalty shoot-out).

A temporary dismissal is when a player commits a cautionable (YC) offence and is punished by an immediate 'suspension' from participating in the next part of the match. The philosophy is that an 'instant punishment' can have a significant and immediate positive influence on the behaviour of the offending player and, potentially, the player's team.

The national FA, confederation or FIFA should approve (for publication in the competition rules) a temporary dismissal protocol within the following guidelines:

Players only

- Temporary dismissals apply to all players (including goalkeepers) but not to cautionable (YC) offences committed by a substitute or substituted player

Referee's signal

- The referee will indicate a temporary dismissal by showing a yellow card and then clearly pointing with both arms to the temporary dismissal area (usually the player's technical area)

Temporary dismissal period

- The length of the temporary dismissal is the same for all offences
- The length of the temporary dismissal should be 10-15% of the total playing time (e.g. 10 minutes in a 90-minute match; 8 minutes in an 80-minute match)
- The temporary dismissal period begins when play restarts after the player has left the field of play
- The referee should include in the temporary dismissal period any time 'lost' for a stoppage for which 'additional time' will be allowed at the end of the half (e.g. substitution, injury, goal celebration, etc.)
- Competitions must decide who will help the referee time the dismissal period – it could be the responsibility of a delegate, fourth official or neutral assistant referee; conversely it could be a team official
- Once the temporary dismissal period has been completed, the player can return from the touchline with the referee's permission, when the ball is next out of play
- The referee has the final decision as to when the player can return
- A temporarily dismissed player can only be substituted after the temporary dismissal period has ended (and only if the team has not used all its permitted substitutes and/or substitution opportunities, if applicable)
- If a temporary dismissal period has not been completed at the end of the first half, the remaining period is served from the start of the second half; this also applies in extra time
- If a temporary dismissal period has not been completed at the end of the second half when extra time is to be played, the remaining period is served from the start of extra time